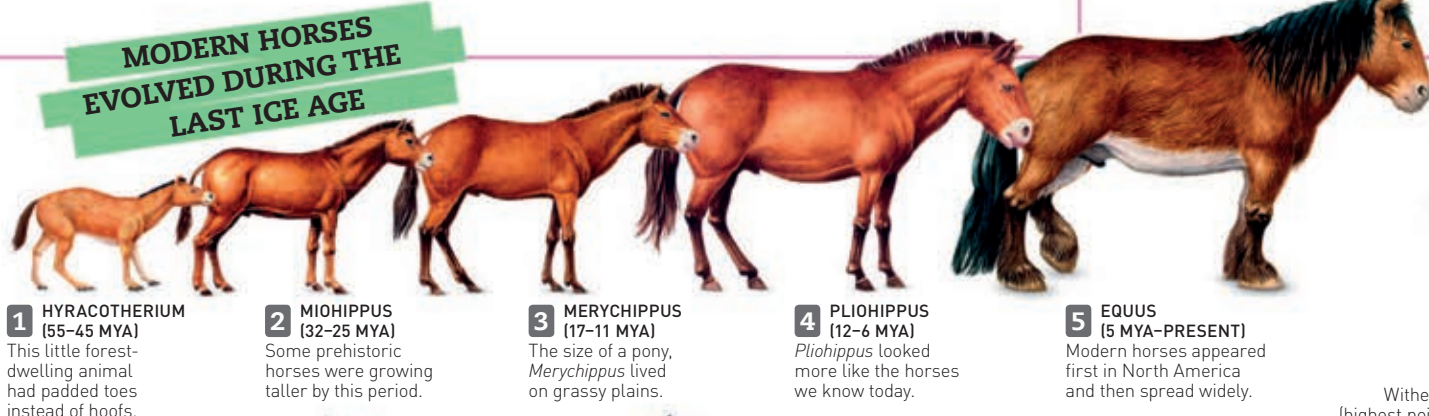


Horses

People are thought to have first tamed wild horses for riding and pulling loads around 6,000 years ago. Until modern times, the horse was the fastest form of transport available and an essential part of farming life. Today, horses are mostly used for leisure riding and other sports. There are hundreds of different breeds of all sizes.

EVOLUTION OF THE HORSE

Forerunners of the horse first appeared 55 million years ago (MYA). These animals, about the size of a small dog, looked very different from modern horses. The pictures here show some of the stages of the horse's evolution.



1 HYRACOTHERIUM (55-45 MYA)
This little forest-dwelling animal had padded toes instead of hoofs.

2 MIOHIPPIUS (32-25 MYA)
Some prehistoric horses were growing taller by this period.

3 MERYCHIPPUS (17-11 MYA)
The size of a pony, *Merychippus* lived on grassy plains.

4 PLIOHIPPIUS (12-6 MYA)
Pliohippus looked more like the horses we know today.

5 EQUUS (5 MYA-PRESENT)
Modern horses appeared first in North America and then spread widely.

HEAVY HORSES

Also called draught or working horses, these large, strongly built animals are bred for hauling heavy loads. They were once widely used for farm work but most of them are now kept for showing and other competitions.



SHIRE

CLYDESDALE

POITEVIN

ARDENNAIS



PERCHERON



NORMAN COB



SUFFOLK PUNCH



JUTLAND

LIGHT HORSES

These horses are smaller and less powerful than draught horses. They are widely used for leisure riding and in sports such as racing, showjumping, and carriage driving.



THOROUGHBRED

ANDALUCIAN

ARABIAN



DANISH WARBLOOD



KNABSTRUP



KARABAKH



APPALOOSA

NAMING PARTS

The various parts of a horse's body have special names, which riders and other people who work with horses always use. These parts are often referred to as the "points" of a horse.

Forelock

Crest (topline of neck)

Withers (highest point of shoulders)

Flank

Hock (joint similar to human ankle)

Fetlock joint

Hoof